

The Validity Net

Note: This is the linearized, screen-reader-optimized version of the “validity net” concept map. The same content arranged as a visual concept map is available as [validity-net-visual.pdf](#).

The Causal Core: IV causes → DV

- Temporal Precedence
- Reliable statistical relationship
- No alternative hypotheses/confounds

Measurement Validity

- Measurement error → bad data → worthless results
- Is the IV properly manipulated?
- Is the DV properly measured?
- Are the values we have for **every** measure/behavior correct?
- Observational, Self-report or Trace?
- Primary or Archival data?

Every Characteristic/Behavior/Procedure is either...

	Constant	Variable
Measured	1	2
Manipulated	3	4

Statistical Conclusion Validity

- IV & DV can't be causally related if not statistically related
- Statistical significance tests
- Programmatic Research – novel RH tests, replication & convergence

Characteristic/Behavior/Procedure

Plays a “Role” in a Study

types & their “roles” in a design

Role	Equivalence
Causal Variable (IV)	4 – Ongoing Eq
Effect Variable (DV)	2 – Ongoing Eq
Control Constant	1 – Initial Eq; 3 – Ongoing Eq
Control Variable	2 – Initial Eq; 4 – Ongoing Eq
Confounding Variable	2 – Initial Eq; 4 – Ongoing Eq

External Validity

Population – Participant Sampling

Stage	Choice or outcome
Target population	Complete or Purposive
Sampling Frame	Researcher-selected or Self-selected
Selected Sample	Simple or Stratified
Data Sample	Attrition

Setting

- Laboratory, Structured or Field?

Task/Stimulus

- Familiar/Representative or Unfamiliar/Control?

Societal/Temporal

- Relationships among variables change over time in a society

Internal Validity

Design

Design	BG	WG
True Experiment	✓	✓
Non-experiment	✗	✗

Legend: ✓ = design supports causal interpretation; ✗ = design does not support causal interpretation.

Initial Equivalence – Participant Assignment

- RA of individual participants by the researcher before manipulation of the IV – best but not a guarantee
- Without proper RA all subject variables are potential confounds
- Subject constants can't be confounding variables
- Subject variables that are equivalent across IV conditions are control variables
- Subject variables that are nonequivalent across IV conditions are confounding variables – even if RA was used (remember RA doesn't always work)

Ongoing Equivalence – Procedural Standardization

- Only the IV is different across IV conditions
- Procedural constants cannot be confounding variables
- Procedural variables that are equivalent across IV conditions are control variables
- Procedural variables that are nonequivalent across IV conditions are confounding variables
- Ongoing equivalence is harder to maintain in field settings
- Ongoing equivalence is harder to maintain during longer procedures

Choices We Make: Representation vs. Control

Choices we make influence Internal and External Validity !!

- **Participants** — representation vs. control
- **Setting** — representation vs. control
- **Task-Stimulus** — representation vs. control